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Sub-imperialism, the highest stage of dependent capitalism

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Based on Ruy Mauro Marini's theses developed within the Marxist Dependency Theory school of thought, this chapter uncovers the foundations for a global theory of sub-imperialism by tackling each level of abstraction that makes up the total phenomenon.[1] Sub-imperialism is considered the result of the laws of dependent capitalism in combination with the world economic system configured by post-World War II capital movements. The arrival of a few socio-economic formations at the highest stage of dependent capitalism along with the rise of intermediate links in the imperialist chain made room for a new hierarchical level in the global order. In this way these formations turn into countries that do not just transfer surplus value to imperialist centres but also succeed in appropriating weaker countries' surplus value by displacing some of the contradictions specific to dependent capitalism. And they develop a policy of antagonistic cooperation with the dominant imperialism.

Ever since imperialism's advent as the highest stage of capitalism, Marxist theorists have sought to define the nature of distinct socio-economic formations in a hierarchically differentiated world system. After the Third International's debates, Marxist vocabulary classified countries as imperialist, colonial and semi-colonial. With the transformations that capitalism underwent in the crisis brought on by the world wars and the decolonisation process, the theory of imperialism had to address the new reality. Terms such as *neo-colonialism* (Nkrumah 1966) and *imperialism without colonies* (Magdoff 1978) were used to express the new type of domination exercised by imperialist powers.